

GOVERNMENT HACK · TROOPTOTEACHER TECHNOLOGIES

Foundations of Constitutional Government

United States Government & Civics (GC) · Unit 1 · GC.01–GC.09

“How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?”

Grades 9–12 · Suggested 8–10 days · Supplemental under TCA § 49-6-2202(a)(3)

Essential Question: How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?

GC.16

Article II & the Presidency

GC.17

Departments of the Executive Branch

GC.18

The Electoral College

Article II & the Presidency

Learning target: I can analyze Article II — the qualifications, powers, roles, term, and succession of the President.

PRIMARY SOURCE



PRIMARY SOURCE • PORTRAIT

**George Washington
(Athenaeum Portrait)**

drop image: GC.16_washington-
portrait.jpg

Gilbert Stuart's George Washington (1796): the first President set the precedents for an office defined by Article II.

“I do solemnly swear (or affirm) that I will faithfully execute the Office of President of the United States, and will to the best of my Ability, preserve, protect and defend the Constitution of the United States.” — **Constitutional Convention, U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 1 (Oath) (1787)**

George Washington (Athenaeum Portrait) • Gilbert Stuart (1796) • Wikimedia Commons

HOOK

One person commands the world's most powerful military — yet cannot make a treaty or hire a cabinet officer alone. Who holds the leash?

KEY VOCABULARY

Commander-in-Chief /kuh-MAN-der in cheef/

comandante en jefe

The President's role as civilian head of the U.S. armed forces, ensuring the military answers to elected leadership.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 2

Which check on the President is built into the treaty and appointment powers of Article II?

- A The President may act only during wartime
- B The Supreme Court must approve every treaty
- C ✓ The Senate must give its 'Advice and Consent'**
- D The House must sign every appointment

Answer: C. DOK 2: Article II gives the President power to make treaties and appointments only 'by and with the Advice and Consent of the Senate' — a legislative check on executive power.

Departments of the Executive Branch

Learning target: I can identify the major executive departments and describe what each one does to carry out the law.

PRIMARY SOURCE



PRIMARY SOURCE • EMBLEM

Seal of the U.S.
Department of State (1900)

drop image: GC.17_executive-
department-seal.png

The Seal of the U.S. Department of State — one of the executive departments that carry out the President's duty to faithfully execute the law.

“...he may require the Opinion, in writing, of the principal Officer in each of the executive Departments, upon any Subject relating to the Duties of their respective Offices.”
— Constitutional Convention, U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 2 (1787)

Seal of the U.S. Department of State (1900) · U.S. Dept. of State (1900) · Wikimedia Commons

HOOK

An outbreak, a counterfeit bill, a border dispute, a school-funding fight — four problems, four different departments. Do you know which handles which?

KEY VOCABULARY

Bureaucracy /byoo-ROK-ruh-see/
burocracia

The departments, agencies, and employees of the executive branch that carry out and administer federal laws and programs day to day.

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 2

Which executive department is chiefly responsible for foreign policy and relations with other countries?

- A The Department of the Treasury
- B ✓ The Department of State**
- C The Department of Defense
- D The Department of Education

Answer: B. DOK 2: The Department of State manages diplomacy and foreign relations; Treasury handles money, Defense the military, Justice the law, and Education federal school policy.

The Electoral College

Learning target: I can explain how the Electoral College works and weigh the arguments for and against it.

PRIMARY SOURCE



PRIMARY SOURCE • CARTOON

The Political Farce of 1876 (Hayes–Tilden)

drop image: GC.18_electoral-college-cartoon.jpg

The disputed 1876 Hayes–Tilden election: a candidate can win the popular vote yet lose the presidency — the Electoral College debate in one image.

“Each State shall appoint, in such Manner as the Legislature thereof may direct, a Number of Electors, equal to the whole Number of Senators and Representatives to which the State may be entitled in the Congress.” —
Constitutional Convention, U.S. Constitution, Article II, Section 1 (1787)

The Political Farce of 1876 (Hayes–Tilden) • (unattributed) (1876) • Library of Congress

HOOK

You never actually vote for President — you vote for someone who does. Meet the electors, and decide if the system still makes sense

KEY VOCABULARY

Electoral College /ee-LEK-tor-ul KOL-ij/

Colegio Electoral

The body of electors — one per senator and representative — that formally elects the President; a candidate needs a majority (270 of 538).

CHECK FOR UNDERSTANDING • DOK 3

Why can a candidate win the national popular vote yet still lose the presidency?

- A Because the Supreme Court chooses the President
- B Because Congress ignores the popular vote entirely
- C Because the President is chosen by the Cabinet
- D ✓** Because most states award all their electoral votes winner-take-all, so the Electoral College total can differ from the national vote

Answer: D. DOK 3: The winner is decided by electoral votes, not the national popular vote; because most states use winner-take-all, a candidate can gather more electoral votes while another wins more total votes nationwide.

How Strong Should the President Be? Perspectives on Executive Power

Energy in the Executive

Hamilton argued a single, energetic executive is essential to act decisively in war and crisis (Federalist 68/70; connects to GC.16).

Fear of a King

Anti-Federalists worried the presidency could become an elected monarchy — a fear that shaped term limits and impeachment (GC.16, connects to Unit 1 GC.04).

The Bureaucracy

Millions of federal employees in departments and agencies carry out the law day to day, raising questions about who really controls policy (GC.17).

The Electoral College

The winner of the most national votes has sometimes lost the presidency, sparking a lasting debate over how we choose a President (GC.18).

Our Signature Move



Tennessee has sent three of its own to the presidency: Andrew Jackson, James K. Polk, and Andrew Johnson all built their careers in Tennessee before reaching the White House. Andrew Johnson's presidency ended in the first impeachment trial of a President — a direct test of the checks on executive power studied in this unit (GC.16).

TASK Three Presidents called Tennessee home. Choose one — Jackson, Polk, or Johnson — and investigate one power of the presidency they used or tested, and record what you find with a source.

Predict • Play • Spiral

Predict First — open the unit

Predict first: Should the candidate with the most votes nationwide always become President? Write your gut answer now — you'll test it against the Electoral College and Hamilton's Federalist 68.

Warm-Up Play — Cabinet Match

2-minute game (GC.17). Read a real problem — a disease outbreak, a border dispute, a counterfeit bill, a civil-rights complaint — and race to name the department that handles it (State, Treasury, Defense, Justice, Education). Students feel how the executive branch divides the work of running the country.

Spiral — retrieve & connect

GC.16 → Unit 3 (GC.15, Senate confirmation)

The Senate that confirms the President's appointments is the same power you studied in the Legislative unit — checks & balances in action.

GC.16 → Unit 1 (GC.06, checks & balances)

The veto, impeachment, and appointment checks all come from the separation of powers you learned in Foundations.

GC.18 → Unit 1 (GC.04, the Great Compromise)

The Electoral College's mix of population and state equality echoes the same large-vs-small-state bargain from the Convention.

Executive Debate

- Cite the clause — point to Article II before you argue.
- Separate the power from the person who used it.
- Disagree with the argument, not the classmate.
- One voice at a time; make room for the quiet voice.

Revisit the Essential Question

“How much power should one person hold — and how is the presidency kept in check?”

Students now have the sources, vocabulary, and reasoning to answer it — in a CER paragraph or the unit DBQ.

GC.16 · GC.17 · GC.18